

The discharge may appear as a thick, clear or yellow clump that looks like mucus from your nose. It's common for small amounts of blood to be present.

Many women think that losing the plug means that labor is imminent, but this is not necessarily the case. In fact, it may be many days before labor starts. However, if loss of the plug is accompanied by other symptoms, such as painful, frequent contractions, heavy bleeding, or leaking fluid (indicating your water has broken), you should call your doctor or hospital immediately.

Water breaking

Rupture of the amniotic membranes, called the water breaking, usually occurs once labor has started but can happen earlier, and often means that labor is imminent. For some, a big gush of fluid is a clear sign that their water has broken, while for others there may be a trickle and it can be hard to determine if the amniotic fluid is leaking. Also, since many women have trouble controlling their bladder in pregnancy, telling the difference between urine and amniotic fluid can be hard. One way to tell is to wear a sanitary pad. If the pad quickly becomes soaked, your water has probably broken. Amniotic fluid also has an odor that is different than urine, even to nonprofessional noses.

Monitoring after the water breaks If you think your water has broken but contractions haven't started, contact your doctor or the hospital for advice. If you're due, there are no complications, and your baby's head is engaged, you may be advised either to stay at home for a while to see if labor starts, or will be asked to be seen at the hospital. This is because, once your water has broken, your baby has lost the protective membrane surrounding them, which means there is an increased risk of an infection reaching your baby. The doctor should check your file to see if you're Group B Strep (GBS)-positive, and if you are, you'll be admitted and started on IV antibiotics. They may also monitor your baby's heartbeat (see [External electronic fetal monitoring](#)) to check that your baby is isn't distressed. If you're GBS-negative and all is well, you may be able to return home, or stay at home, for a set amount of time and an appointment will be made to see how you're progressing. If labor doesn't start within 24 hours (the timeframe may be shorter in some hospitals), the hospital may suggest an induction (see [Induction of labor](#)).

Early contractions

As your body prepares to go into labor, you will start to experience mild and irregular contractions. These differ from Braxton Hicks since they build gradually and will soften and dilate the cervix.

WHEN TO SEEK HELP

Make your way to the hospital or seek advice if any of the following occurs:

- You have vaginal bleeding that is like a period or heavier.
- You're leaking amniotic fluid or leaking greenish fluid that could indicate the baby is distressed.
- The baby isn't moving as expected (ask your doctor for advice).

When am I in labor?

A common concern of many women is how they will know when they are in labor. The following are indications that labor is truly underway.

- **You are having contractions that are becoming stronger** and more intense, lasting longer, and the interval between the contractions is getting shorter.